Reading practice booklet: Grade 4 expectations

Grade 4 · Practice booklet

Name: _____

What this booklet is

This is general practice written for Reading at Grade 4 level, following the Common Core State Standards for English Language Arts standards for that grade. It is not made from your child's MAP questions, and it does not replace the classroom. Use it as a guide to what a child is expected to know and do at this level.

How to use it

- Do one section at a time, about 10 minutes, 3 days a week. Stop while it is still enjoyable.
- Read each question all the way through, twice, before answering. Underline the key words and say what is being asked.
- Take your time. A careful, correct answer is worth more than a fast one.
- Use scrap paper and show the working. Then check the answer before moving on.
- Ask your child to explain how they got an answer, even when it is right.
- If a section feels too hard, do the section before it again, or ask the teacher. That is part of learning, not a problem.

Section 1: Word meanings and how writers use words

Standards practised: L.4.4, L.4.4a, L.4.5, L.4.5a, RL.4.4, RF.4.3, RF.4.4

A worked example

In the story, "The dates are ripe, which means they are ready to be picked." What does ripe mean?

1. Look for a clue near the word. The sentence says "which means they are ready to be picked."
2. So ripe must mean fully grown and ready to eat or harvest.

Ripe means fully grown and ready to be picked.

The Date Harvest

Salem and his grandfather walked into the oasis at dawn. The morning air was cool, but Salem knew the day would be scorching, so hot that the sand would burn bare feet by noon. Grandfather carried a long knife and a basket. "Today we harvest," he said. "The dates are ripe, which means they are ready to be picked."

Salem looked up. The palm trees were tall giants, and their branches waved like green flags in the breeze. Heavy bunches of golden dates hung just below the leaves. Salem raised his palm to shade his eyes. "How do we reach them?" he asked.

Grandfather smiled and tied a rope around the trunk and his waist. He leaned back and climbed, one careful step after another, until he was among the leaves. A bunch dropped into a net below. Salem sorted the fruit. Some dates were plump and glossy. Others were shriveled, wrinkled and dry from too little water. He put those aside.

By noon the sun was a blazing coin in the sky. Salem's shirt was soaked with sweat, and his throat was parched. Grandfather poured him a cup of cold water from a clay jar. Salem drank it quickly, and it felt like a miracle.

"You worked hard," said Grandfather. "A farmer must be patient. A good harvest cannot be rushed."

Salem bit into a soft date. It was so sweet that he nearly laughed. "I would work all day for this," he said. Grandfather chuckled. "Then you are a true farmer."

Questions

1. The story says the day would be "scorching, so hot that the sand would burn bare feet." What does scorching mean?

2. Salem "raised his palm to shade his eyes." Does palm mean the inside of the hand or a kind of tree here? How can you tell?

3. The branches "waved like green flags in the breeze." What two things are being compared?

4. What does shriveled mean in "shriveled, wrinkled and dry"? Use the clues around the word.

5. Salem's "throat was parched." What does parched tell you about how he felt?

6. The author writes, "the sun was a blazing coin in the sky." What does this metaphor help you picture?

7. The cold water "felt like a miracle." What does this phrase tell you about the water?

8. Grandfather says, "A good harvest cannot be rushed." What does rushed mean here?

9. Grandfather says a farmer must be patient. What does patient mean? Give a clue from the story.

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10. Which word from the story is the opposite of plump: glossy, shriveled or ripe?

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11. Write your own sentence using palm to mean a kind of tree.

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12. Explain, in your own words, what Grandfather means by "Then you are a true farmer."

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13. Say the word miracle slowly and split it into syllables. How many syllables does it have?

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14. Split these two words from the story into syllables: shriveled and scorching.

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15. Grandfather takes "one careful step after another." The word careful is made from care and the ending -ful. What does the ending -ful mean, and so what does careful mean?

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16. Fluency task: read the paragraph that begins "By noon" aloud to a grown-up, twice, in a clear voice. What should the grown-up listen for?

Section 2: Reading nonfiction

Standards practised: RI.4.1, RI.4.2, RI.4.3, RI.4.5, RI.4.8, L.4.4, RI.4.4, RI.4.6, RI.4.7

A worked example

What is the main idea of the first paragraph?

1. Ask what the whole paragraph is mostly about.
2. It describes the oryx, says hunting left none in the wild, and says people worked to save it.
3. Put that into one sentence.

The Arabian oryx was lost from the wild, but people worked together to save it.

Text A: The Return of the Arabian Oryx

The Arabian oryx is a tall, graceful antelope with a white coat and two long, straight horns. It once roamed across the deserts of the Arabian Peninsula. By the 1970s, hunting had left none living in the wild. Thankfully, people worked together to save it.

Conservationists gathered a small group of oryx and cared for them in protected places. They bred the animals carefully, and the herds grew. In 1982, oryx were returned to the wild in Oman. Later, herds were also released in protected reserves in the United Arab Emirates. At one release, trucks carried a group of oryx to the reserve gate at sunrise. Rangers opened the crates, and the herd walked out into the open desert, where oryx now live.

The oryx is wonderfully suited to desert life. Its pale coat reflects the sunlight, which helps keep the animal cool. Its wide hooves spread out like paddles, so the oryx does not sink into soft sand. It can also go for many days without drinking. It gets much of its water from the plants it eats, and it often feeds at night and in the early morning, when the air is cooler. During the hottest hours of the day, it rests in the shade.

Today, the Arabian oryx is a symbol of hope. Rangers watch over the herds and count them each year, and the numbers are growing. The story of the

oryx shows that when people care and work together, an animal that was almost lost can come back.

Text B: Release Day, from a Ranger's Diary

I woke before sunrise on release day, too excited to eat breakfast. My team and I had waited many months for this morning. At the gate of the reserve, the trucks arrived, and I could hear the oryx moving inside their crates. My hands were shaking when I helped to slide the first door open.

For a moment, nothing happened. Then a young oryx stepped out, lifted her head and sniffed the desert air. My heart thumped. One by one, the others followed, their white coats glowing in the early light. They trotted across the sand, and soon they were small shapes beside a ghaf tree. I was so proud I could hardly speak. I know I will never forget this morning.

Text C: Counting the Herd

Rangers at a desert reserve in the United Arab Emirates count their oryx every year. The table below shows what they found over four years.

Year | Oryx counted Year 1 | 40 Year 2 | 46 Year 3 | 55 Year 4 | 67

The rangers say the herd is healthy because it is a little bigger each year.

Questions

1. What is the main idea of the whole of Text A?

   _____

2. What caused the oryx to disappear from the wild?

   _____

3. What did conservationists do to help the oryx?

   _____

4. When were oryx first returned to the wild, and in which country?

5. How does the oryx's pale coat help it?

6. Why are the oryx's hooves wide?

7. How can the oryx go many days without drinking?

8. Why does the oryx often feed at night and early morning?

9. The text has a problem and a solution. What is the problem? What is the solution?

10. From Text A, what do you think conservationists means?

11. Give two details from Text A that show the oryx is "wonderfully suited to desert life."

12. Why does the author call the oryx "a symbol of hope"?

13. In Text A, "They bred the animals carefully, and the herds grew." What does bred mean here? Which clue helps you?

14. Text A and Text B both tell about a release of oryx at a reserve. Which one is a firsthand account, and how can you tell?

15. Use the table in Text C. How many more oryx were counted in Year 4 than in Year 1?

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16. Text A says only that "the numbers are growing." What does the table in Text C add to this?

Section 3: Stories, poems and plays

Standards practised: RL.4.1, RL.4.2, RL.4.3, RL.4.4, RL.4.6, L.4.5a, RL.4.5, RL.4.9

A worked example

Where and when does Text A begin?

1. Look at the first sentence for time and place clues.
2. It says "a breezy Saturday afternoon" and "down to the beach."

On a breezy Saturday afternoon, at the beach.

Text A: Omar's Kite

On a breezy Saturday afternoon, Omar carried his new red kite down to the beach. The sea sparkled, and the sand was warm under his feet. His cousin Hind was already flying a yellow kite high above the waves.

"Watch this," said Omar. He ran across the sand and let go of the string. The kite wobbled, spun around and fell. He tried again. It crashed into the sand. The third time, it tangled in the string. Omar threw the spool down and folded his arms. "This kite is broken," he grumbled. "I give up."

Hind came over and looked at the kite carefully. "It is not broken," she said. "It just needs a longer tail. The tail keeps it steady, like a rudder on a boat." She took a strip of cloth from her bag and tied it on.

Omar sighed, but he picked up the string. This time he waited for a strong gust of wind before he let go. The kite rose, wobbled once, and then climbed steadily. Soon it was gliding near Hind's yellow one, two bright spots against the blue sky.

Omar laughed so hard he almost forgot to hold on. "I nearly quit," he said.

"Everyone's first tries are bumpy," said Hind. "You just have to keep trying and fix one small thing at a time."

As the sun sank toward the water, Omar watched his kite. He decided that tomorrow he would teach his little brother Khalid how to fly one too.

Text B: Maryam's Mint

Maryam planted six mint seeds in a blue pot on the balcony of her family's flat in Dubai. She gave them a few drops of water every morning and waited. After a week, small green shoots appeared, but by the weekend they were drooping and yellow.

"It is no use," Maryam sighed. "Gardening is too hard." She pushed the pot into the corner. Grandmother, who was sipping karak nearby, only smiled. "Plants cannot talk, but they can show us what they need," she said.

Maryam frowned at the sad shoots. She noticed that the afternoon sun hit the pot hard and that the soil was dry and cracked. Perhaps the sun was too fierce. She dragged the pot into the shade of the big wall and gave it a good drink of water.

The next morning, nothing had changed. The morning after that, a few leaves lifted. By the end of the week, the shoots were tall and green and smelled of fresh mint. Maryam grinned. "I almost threw them away," she said. "Next time, I will watch carefully and change one thing at a time." Grandmother laughed and poured her a cup of mint tea.

Questions

1. Why is the beach a good place to fly a kite? Use a detail from Text A.

2. How does Omar feel after his third try? Give a detail that shows it.

3. What does Hind notice is wrong with the kite?

4. What does the tail do for the kite?

5. What does the phrase "like a rudder on a boat" compare?

6. What did Omar do differently on his last try?

7. Describe Hind in one or two words and give a detail that shows it.

8. How is Omar different at the end of Text A from the beginning?

9. Who is telling Text A: a character in it, or a narrator outside it? How can you tell?

10. What is the theme (the lesson) of Text A?

11. Which words from Text A best support that theme?

12. Why do you think Omar wants to teach Khalid tomorrow?

13. Text A and Text B are different stories, but they share a similar theme. What is that shared theme?

14. In Text A, Omar gets help from Hind to fix his problem. How does Maryam solve her problem in Text B?

15. Read this poem. The sun climbs up from the sea so blue, The wind comes in and the kite flies too. I tug, I run, and I let it go, A bright red spot where the soft clouds flow. Which word at the end of a line rhymes with blue, and what do we call a group of lines like these in a poem?

16. Read this part of a play. Cast: Maryam, a girl; Grandmother. Setting: A kitchen in Sharjah. MARYAM (looking at a tray of cookies, sadly): My cookies are too dark! GRANDMOTHER (smiling kindly): We will bake them again together. Name two features that show this is a play and not a story.

Answer guide for parents

Section 1: Word meanings and how writers use words

1. Extremely hot (the clue is "so hot that the sand would burn").
2. The inside of the hand: he used it to shade his eyes.
3. The palm branches and green flags.
4. Shrunk and wrinkled from losing water.
5. Parched means very dry, so he was very thirsty.
6. A bright, round, very hot sun.
7. It felt wonderful and was just what he needed.
8. Done too quickly, in a hurry.
9. Able to wait calmly without hurrying (for example, carefully climbing one step at a time).
10. Shriveled.
11. Answers vary. Example: A tall palm grew beside the well.
12. Salem is willing to work hard and be patient for something good, as a real farmer is.
13. Three: mir-a-cle.
14. shriv-eled (two syllables) and scorch-ing (two syllables).
15. The ending -ful means full of, so careful means full of care (taking care).
16. Most words read correctly without long stops; a steady pace, not too fast or too slow; a short pause at each comma and full stop; a voice that shows what Grandfather and Salem say in the quotation marks; going back to fix a word that did not make sense. The second reading should sound smoother than the first.

Section 2: Reading nonfiction

1. The Arabian oryx, once gone from the wild, was saved by people and is well suited to desert life.
2. Hunting.
3. They cared for a small group in protected places and bred them so the herds grew.
4. In 1982, in Oman.
5. It reflects sunlight and keeps the animal cool.
6. So it does not sink into soft sand.
7. It gets much of its water from the plants it eats.
8. The air is cooler then.
9. Problem: no oryx were left in the wild. Solution: people bred them and returned them to the wild.
10. People who work to protect animals and nature.
11. Any two: pale coat reflects sun; wide hooves; goes days without drinking; feeds when cooler; rests in shade.
12. Because an animal almost lost has come back, showing that people can make a difference.
13. Bred means helped the animals to have young (the clue is "the herds grew").
14. Text B: it is written by a ranger who was there, uses I and my, and tells what the writer saw and felt. Text A is a secondhand account, written by someone reporting facts

about the release.
15. 27 more (67 minus 40).
16. It gives the exact number counted each year, so you can see how much the herd grew (from 40 to 67 in four years).

Section 3: Stories, poems and plays

1. It is breezy (there is wind).
2. Frustrated; he throws the spool down, folds his arms and says "I give up."
3. It needs a longer tail.
4. It keeps the kite steady.
5. A kite's tail and a boat's rudder, since both keep things steady.
6. He waited for a strong gust of wind before letting go.
7. Helpful or kind: she fixes the kite with a strip of cloth.
8. At first he wants to give up; at the end he is happy and wants to teach his brother.
9. A narrator outside it, using names and words like he and she.
10. Keep trying and fix one small thing at a time instead of giving up.
11. Hind says, "You just have to keep trying and fix one small thing at a time."
12. He is proud and happy and wants to share what he learned.
13. Do not give up: keep trying and change one small thing at a time.
14. Grandmother gives only a hint, and Maryam works it out herself: she watches the shoots, notices the sun is too fierce and moves the pot into the shade.
15. Too rhymes with blue. A group of lines in a poem is called a stanza (a verse).
16. Any two: a cast of characters is listed; the setting is described at the start; each line begins with the speaker's name; stage directions in brackets tell the actor how to act or speak.